

EVOLUTION OF MUSLIM NATIONALISM IN SUBCONTINENT

PART ONE

ISLAM IN SUBCONTINENT

EARLIEST MUSLIM INDIANS

- Before the rise of Islam, the Arab traders had trade relations with Subcontinent. They had set up trade colonies on the western coast of India mainly in Gujrat and Kerala, where they used to trade in horses, spices and silk.
- Many Indians accepted Islam, first mosque of India-Cheraman Juma Mosque was built in Kerala by Cheraman Perumal Bhaskara Ravi Varma, the first muslim from India.
- Through continued trade between Arabs and Indians, Islam continued to spread initially in coastal Indian cities and towns, both through immigration and conversion.

RELIGIONS IN INDIA

- Before Islam there were three main religions in India.
 - a. Hinduism
 - b. Buddhism
 - c. Jainism
- Buddhism and Jainism were taking their last breath because they could not compete with Hinduism. With the advent of Islam, the foundations of caste ridden Hinduism were shaken.
- Islam preached equality of human beings and worship of one God (monotheism) instead of various gods (polytheism)

MUSLIM EXPEDITIONS TO INDIA

- Muslim conquests in Indian Subcontinent mainly took place from 13th to 16th century, though early Muslim conquests made inroads into modern North India and Pakistan as early as the time of Rajput kingdoms in the 7th century.
- The first incursion took place by Arabs from coastal regions of India and then were resumed under Turkic and Central Asian Mongol dynasties with locals and expanded their domains both northwards and eastwards.
- Muslim Mughal empire was able to subjugate most of the India's Hindu kings, however were not able to conquer the Hindu kingdoms like Himachel Pardesh, Uttarkhand, Nepal and Bhutan.

PHASES OF MUSLIM CONQUESTS

- After the death of Hazrat Muhammad (SAW) many expeditions were sent towards subcontinent during the caliphate period.
- The **first expedition** was sent by **Hazrat Umar (R.A.)** under Usman bin Abi Aas towards **Thana and Barouch**, small sea port near **Bombay**.
- During his reign, the coastal region of Balochistan, Makran was also conquered in 642AD under the command of Hakam Taglabi.
- Hazrat Usman (R.A.) sent Hakim bin Jabala to Sind in 650 AD.

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- During the Ummayyad dynasty (Al-Malik), Muhammad bin Qasim challenged Raja Dahir for a battle in 712 AD and defeated him.
- Lower caste hindus and followers of Jainism greatly helped him because they were oppressed by Raja Dahir. He conquered whole Sindh and Multan when he was called back.
- According to an Italian scholar, Gabriel

“Present day Pakistan, holding the value of Islam in such a high esteem, should look upon the young Arab conqueror, Muhammad bin Qasim, as a distant Kistes (founding father), a hero of South Asian Islam.”

EFFECTS OF CONQUEST

- This conquest resulted in far reaching political, social, cultural and religious effects. Islamic principles of Tauheed, equality and fraternity allured a lot of non-muslims to Islam. Religious rights were guaranteed.
- Hindus learnt art of trade, navigation, dressing, eating and the Arabs learnt the knowledge of astrology from Indians.
- In political field, arrangements made by him provided base for later Muslim policy in subcontinent. All taxes were abolished and only jizya was imposed.
- Social caste system was also eradicated and human dignity was restored as every one was considered equal and civil security was assured.

MUSLIM INVASIONS FROM NORTHWEST

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- The successive waves of Muslims penetration into India was from northwest. At the end of 10th century, Turks entered India through Khyber pass. Mahmud Ghaznavi attacked India many times from 1001-1027, but for the consolidation of his empire in Central Asia and not for the spread of Islam. He was titled as Idol Breaker.
 - As Abbasid empire was declining, Ghazni had become a major political, military and cultural center. It also served as base for operations against subcontinent.

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- He annexed Lahore and as southern parts were already under Muslim influence, the whole area of present day Pakistan came under Muslim rule. Persian was introduced that later became literary and official language of Muslims.

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- Muslim power was further expanded in India by Shahab ud din Muhammad Ghauri. He conquered Delhi and established Muslim rule in India. In 1192, he defeated Raj Chauhan and invaded Indo-Gangetic Plain, conquering in succession Ghazni, Multan, Sind, Lahore and Delhi.
- He did not have heir and his slave Qutub Uddin Aibak in 1206 founded first Muslim dynasty of Delhi Sultanate i.e. the Mamluk Dynasty (1206-1290).

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- Khilji dynasty (1290-1320) succeeded Mamluk dynasty.
 - Tughlaq dynasty (1320-1413) succeeded Khilji dynasty.
 - Sayyid dynasty (1414-1451) succeeded Tughlaq dynasty.
 - Lodhi dynasty (1451-1526) succeeded Sayyid dynasty.

ROLE OF MUSLIM SAINTS AND SUFIS

- The Muslim sufi saints and Sufis like shaikh Ismail, Ali Muakhdoom Hajveri, Moin Uddin Chisti Ajmeri, Baha Uddin Zakiria, Sheikh Farid Uddin, Khawaja Bakhtiyar Kaki, Nizam Uddin Olia
- and Mashaikh like Hazrat Mujaddid Alif Sani, Hazrat Shah Wali ullah rejected vices and mal practices in India. They presented the pure practical picture of the teachings of Islam and got huge conversions.

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- Islam could not be absorbed in Hinduism. Deen0e0Illahi, Bakhti Movement, Brahmo Samaj, Arya Samaj etc. Created reaction amongst the Muslim Ullema and Mashaikh to preserve the pure Islamic character and save it from external onslaught.
- Equality and social justice inspired conversions to Islam.

MUGHAL ERA

- The Mughal empire was founded by Turco-Mongol leader Babur in 1526 by defeating Ibrahim Lodhi, the last ruler of Delhi Sultanate at the first Battle of Panipat.
- Mughal empire lasted from 1526 to 1857 and Humayun, Akbar, Jehangir, Shah Jehan and Aurangzeb were prominent rulers of this empire.
- During the reign of Humayun, Sher Shah Suri conquered the territory and ruled from (1540-1555).
- Mughal empire was regained in second Battle of Panipat in 1556 by Akbar.

ARRIVAL OF EUROPEAN NATIONS IN SUBCONTINENT

- Akbar was succeeded by Jahangir and he signed a treaty with British East India Company in 1612, opening India for Britain for first time for trade purposes. Thomas Roe became first English ambassador to Mughal court.
- East India Company founded several trading posts at Surat (1632), Orissa (1633), Madras, Chennai in 1639, Calcutta in 1690. By 1700, the company extended its trade and commercial activities in Bengal.
- During the last quarter of 17th century, the company transformed itself from peaceful trading body to political body and established itself as a leading player in Indian Politics because of political disorder in subcontinent.

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- After the death of Aurangzeb, military weakness of Arabs became manifest and Marhatta caused great havoc in Mughal empire and the pace of disintegration became precipitate.
 - In 1739, Nadir shah invaded Delhi and massacred its inhabitants.
 - In 1757, Battle of Plassey brought rich Bengal under British Influence.

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- Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan tried to reverse the trend of disintegration in Southern India but failed in spite of their bravery, ability and resourcefulness.
 - Politically eighteenth century remained a period of defeat and disintegration, but in cultural and religious spheres it was time of reconstruction.
 - Muslim educational system was standardized and generally adopted over subcontinent. Urdu became literary language capable of giving expression to the thoughts, feelings and learning of Muslims.

DECLINE OF MUGHAL EMPIRE

- **Causes of decline of Mughal Empire**

- a. Weak successors of Aurangzeb
- b. Weak central government
- c. Lack of resources
- d. Backward in education
- e. Luxurious life
- f. Weak military force
- g. Lack of naval power
- h. Foreign invasions
- i. Undue liberal policies of Akbar

IMPACT OF ISLAM ON SUBCONTINENT

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- Islam gained a quick and unmatched popularity throughout the subcontinent. By the end of 14th century Islam had penetrated in all parts of India making its incredible impact on the cultural, social and religious conditions of India.
 - Islam introduced not only new religion but a new civilization, a new way of life, new set of values. Islamic traditions of art and literature, culture and refinement of social and welfare institution were established throughout the subcontinent.
 - A new language Urdu derived from Persian, Arabic, Turkish and native words and idioms gained currency in Indian population.

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- Islam is based on reason and logic and is free from superstition and irrational beliefs.
 - All men are equal and it banishes all barriers of race, wealth and status, colour, language or nationality. Muslim rulers implemented this ideology in subcontinent that was a caste ridden society and shed away the yolk of perpetual subordination.
 - Basic principles of oneness of God, equality and brotherhood impressed idol worshippers.
 - Significant developments took place in Hindu architecture also.